

The Epistemic Basis of David Grusch's UAP Claims: A Firsthand-vs-Secondhand Breakdown

TL;DR

- Grusch's foundational 2023 claims (a multi-decade crash-retrieval/reverse-engineering program, recovered non-human craft, non-human "biologics," deaths/injuries) were framed almost entirely as **secondhand** — based on what he was told by witnesses he interviewed, plus documents and photographs others showed him — and he explicitly stated under oath that he had **not personally seen** craft or bodies.
- The popular "purely secondhand" summary is largely correct for 2023 but **imprecise in two directions**: even then he claimed *firsthand* interaction with alleged evidence (he personally interviewed witnesses and reviewed some documents/photographs), and beginning with a November 21, 2025 Fox News interview he

escalated to a firsthand claim — that he personally "read the intelligence reports" and saw photographic proof "with [his] own eyes."

- His most recent claims (June 9, 2026 "slush funds" and "several species/sentient plasma life") were framed as products of **his own official investigation** (slush funds) versus **unattributed/relayed government knowledge** with no evidence offered (the species claim). AARO's 2024 finding that *none* of its ~30 interviewees had firsthand program knowledge directly undercuts the secondhand chain Grusch relied on.

Key Findings

1. Grusch's own framing in 2023 was explicitly secondhand-by-design. In his July 26, 2023 sworn opening statement he said: "My testimony is based on information I have been given by individuals with a longstanding track record of legitimacy and service to this country – many of whom also shared compelling evidence in the form of photography, official documentation, and classified oral testimony." [house](#) He added the decisive caveat: "as I stand here under oath now, I am speaking to the facts as I have been told them." [house](#) When Rep. Robert Garcia asked whether the government possesses UAP, Grusch answered: "Absolutely, based on interviewing over 40 witnesses over 4 years."

2. He claimed firsthand interaction with evidence about the program, even while disclaiming firsthand observation of the craft/bodies. This is the most-missed nuance. Grusch personally interviewed witnesses and personally reviewed documents and photographs; he just had not seen the physical objects. NewsNation reported he "has not seen photos of the alleged craft himself," yet he also told NewsNation he had "seen 'some interesting photos'" and "read some very interesting reports." The accurate characterization: he is firsthand on *documentary/photographic evidence he was shown and witnesses he interviewed*, but secondhand (or further removed) on the *underlying physical reality*.

3. By late 2025 he escalated to a firsthand claim. On Fox News' "Special Report with Bret Baier" (Nov. 21, 2025), after regaining his security clearance and joining Rep. Eric Burlison's staff, Grusch said he "had partial access to the data and actually read the intelligence reports resulting from those programs," and when Baier asked "with your own eyes — you saw it?" Grusch answered "Yes." This is a documented departure from his 2023 position.

4. Skeptics — led by former AARO director Sean Kirkpatrick — characterize the entire chain as "circular reporting." AARO's 2024 Historical Record Report, based on approximately 30 interviews, concluded that "none of the interviewees had

firsthand knowledge of these programs," and that the reverse-engineering narrative is "in large part, the result of circular reporting from a group of individuals."

Details: Claim-by-Claim Categorization

A. The crash-retrieval and reverse-engineering program — SECONDHAND (told/briefed-about, then denied access)

The claim: A multi-decade U.S. program recovers and reverse-engineers craft of non-human origin.

Framing: Grusch said in his opening statement: "I was informed, in the course of my official duties, of a multi-decade UAP crash retrieval and reverse engineering program to which I was denied access."

This is critical — he was *informed of* the program and *denied access* to it; he was never read into it. To NewsNation he described how "senior, former intelligence officers ... confided in me that they were part of a program ... They told me, based on their oral testimony, and they provided me documents and other proof." [NewsNation](#)

Verdict: Secondhand testimony plus

documents/photographs reviewed firsthand. Not personal participation.

**B. Recovered craft of "non-human origin" —
RELAYED (analysis by others), with documents
reviewed firsthand**

The claim: The U.S. possesses "quite a number" of intact and partially intact "non-human exotic origin vehicles."

Framing: In The Debrief (June 5, 2023), Grusch attributed the determination to others' analysis: objects are "of exotic origin (non-human intelligence ...) based on the vehicle morphologies and material science testing and the possession of unique atomic arrangements and radiological signatures." He told NewsNation he "thought it was totally nuts ... at first." NewsNation explicitly stated: "Grusch also said he has not seen photos of the alleged craft himself, but has spoken extensively with other intelligence officials who have."

Verdict: Relayed conclusion; Grusch is at least one step removed from the physical craft.

**C. Recovered "non-human biologics"/bodies —
SECONDHAND (explicitly attributed to others);
CONFIRMED he did not personally see them in
2023**

The claim: "Biologics came with some of these recoveries."

Framing (exact wording): Under questioning by Rep. Nancy Mace, Grusch said: "As I've stated publicly already ... biologics came with some of these recoveries, yeah." Asked if human or non-human: "Non-human, and that was the assessment of people with direct knowledge on the program I talked to that are currently still on the program." Multiple outlets confirmed he "had not personally seen alien bodies or aircraft."

Important nuance on "I personally interviewed those individuals": When Mace asked whether he had spoken to people with direct knowledge, Grusch said "Yes, I personally interviewed those individuals" [CBS News](#) — the firsthand element is the *interviewing*, not the seeing of bodies.

Verdict: Clearly secondhand in 2023. (Note the 2025 escalation in Section H.)

D. "I know the exact locations" of UAPs in U.S. possession — MIXED (asserted as known to him; basis is relayed)

The claim: Grusch knows where recovered UAP are held.

Framing (exact transcript): Garcia: "do you believe that our government is in possession of UAPs?"
Grusch: "Absolutely, based on interviewing over 40

witnesses over 4 years." Garcia: "And where?" Grusch: "I know the exact locations and those locations were provided to the Inspector General and some of which to the intelligence committees. I actually had the people with the firsthand knowledge provide a protected disclosure to the Inspector General."

Verdict: He asserts personal knowledge of locations, but the stated basis is the witnesses' firsthand knowledge, not his own observation. He explicitly routes the actual firsthand sourcing to others ("the people with the firsthand knowledge").

E. People "harmed or injured" in connection with the programs – FIRSTHAND (claimed personal knowledge) for injuries; AMBIGUOUS/RELAYED for deaths

The claim: People have been hurt, and possibly killed, in connection with the programs/cover-up.

Framing (exact transcript): Rep. Burchett: "Do you have any personal knowledge of people who have been harmed or injured in efforts to cover up or conceal these extraterrestrial technology?" Grusch: "Yes, personally." Burchett: "Have ... anyone been murdered that you ... know of or have heard of, I guess?" Grusch: "I have to be careful asking that question. I directed people with that knowledge to the appropriate authorities."

Nuance: For injuries, Grusch said "Yes, personally" – a

firsthand-knowledge claim. To NewsNation he said of program workers, "A lot of them were injured looking at some of this stuff ... a lot of them have literally suffered physically." On murder, he deflected and pointed to others who held the knowledge — i.e., not his own firsthand knowledge.

Verdict: Firsthand *knowledge* claim for harm/injury and for his own retaliation; relayed/deflected for deaths.

F. Retaliation against himself — FIRSTHAND

This is his single most clearly firsthand category. He testified to "administrative terrorism," fearing for his life "personally," and an open whistleblower-reprisal investigation. Fox News quoted him in 2023: "what I personally witnessed myself and my wife was very disturbing." His ICIG complaint — formally a "Disclosure of Urgent Concern(s); Complaint of Reprisal," dated May 25, 2022, signed by Irvin Charles McCullough III (the first-ever ICIG) of Compass Rose Legal Group and filed with then-ICIG Thomas A. Monheim — was found "credible and urgent" in July 2022 [thedebrief](#). His initial confidential disclosure to the DoD Inspector General was made in July 2021.

Critical distinction: the "credible and urgent" finding addresses whether his *complaint about withholding/reprisal* met that statutory threshold — not whether the underlying UFO claims are true.

G. The 1933 Mussolini/Vatican craft — FIRSTHAND DOCUMENT REVIEW; the claim itself is far-removed historical hearsay

The claim: A craft recovered by Mussolini's Italy in 1933, procured by the U.S. ~1944–45 with Vatican and Five Eyes assistance.

Framing: Grusch said he had *viewed documents* reporting this — a firsthand interaction with documents, but the substance is a historical claim he did not witness. NewsNation's own follow-up investigation in Magenta, Italy "yielded little," finding no corroboration; a lifelong local resident "said he had never heard stories about a UFO crash."

Verdict: Firsthand on the documents; the event itself is decades-removed historical hearsay with no independent corroboration.

H. The November 2025 escalation to firsthand evidence review

After regaining his clearance (restored by Nov. 2023 following the Burlison amendment) and becoming Burlison's Special Advisor (March 2025), Grusch's framing shifted. On Fox News' Special Report with Bret Baier (Nov. 21, 2025) he said he had "partial access to the data and actually read the intelligence reports resulting from those programs"; confirmed "Yes" to seeing it "with [his] own eyes"; and, when

Baier asked about visuals of the remains, confirmed "There were, yes, there were." He said "we've recovered the vehicles and we actually have physical proof" and described "non-human biological sentience piloting crafts that do not look like humans."

Key caveat: Even here the firsthand element is *reading intelligence reports and viewing imagery*, not personally handling craft or bodies. He explicitly told Baier the origin "remains a subject of hot debate," that he "did not see that specific data" on extraterrestrial origin, and that he is "not conversant in the high confidence theories the U.S. government holds." So the 2025 "firsthand" claim is best read as "I personally read the classified reporting and saw photos," not "I personally observed the physical craft/bodies."

Note on the promised op-ed: In December 2023 Grusch told NewsNation's Elizabeth Vargas, "I will be discussing what I actually do know firsthand. I just could not overtly discuss that at the time."

[NewsNation](#) That promised op-ed was never published; the firsthand disclosure ultimately came via the November 2025 Fox interview instead.

I. June 9, 2026 "slush funds" — FRAMED AS HIS OWN INVESTIGATIVE FINDING (firsthand)

At a Capitol Hill press conference (with Reps. Luna, Burchett, Burlison, Moskowitz; plus Leslie Kean and James Fox), Grusch tied the allegation to the

administration's fraud task force: "President Vance's task force is sharply focused on the issue of misuse of funds. The same accountability problem applies here, and during my investigation, I found slush funds to the tune of billions of dollars per annum for these activities," calling it "a real fraud, waste and abuse issue." He specifically accused the Defense Intelligence Agency of obstructing oversight and urged release of records.

Verdict: Framed as a firsthand finding of his own investigation. No documentary evidence was presented publicly.

J. June 9, 2026 "several species / sentient plasma life" — RELAYED/UNATTRIBUTED, no evidence

Asked how many non-human species the government is aware of, Grusch said: "It's a continuum from corporeal bipedal type life to, you know, what I would consider is like sentient plasma life. But there are several that this government is aware of." Reporting consistently notes "He did not elaborate on the claim or provide evidence during the event." [Fox News](#) At the same event he also alleged the government is aware of "several dozen" cases involving non-human biologics and holds audio/video related to crash retrievals, including images of recovered craft.

Verdict: Framed as government knowledge ("this

government is aware of"), not as his own firsthand observation; no basis or evidence given. (A February 2026 documentary clip reportedly has him claiming "first-hand exposure to non-human sentient beings," [Unidentified Phenomena](#) but this rests on a single UFO-enthusiast aggregator and could not be verified to a primary source — treat as unconfirmed.)

The Critical/Skeptical Analyses

Sean Kirkpatrick (former AARO director): In his January 2024 Scientific American op-ed he wrote that the coverup allegations "derive from inadvertent or unauthorized disclosures of legitimate U.S. programs ... that have nothing to do with extraterrestrial issues or technology," and that "the narrative is a textbook example of circular reporting, with each person relaying what they heard, but the information often ultimately being sourced to the same small group of individuals." He described proponents as "a small group of interconnected believers and others with possibly less than honest intentions" promoting "a whirlwind of tall tales, fabrication and secondhand or thirdhand retellings." To Peter Bergen (2024) he said of Grusch specifically: "this core group of people have influenced him ... He may have misinterpreted things that people have said, or he may have just fallen into

the influence of what these folks have been telling him."

AARO Historical Record Report Vol. 1 (released March 8, 2024): Based on interviews with approximately 30 people, AARO concluded: "none of the interviewees had firsthand knowledge of these programs—they were not approved for access to nor did they work on these efforts—which likely resulted in misinterpretation of the programs' origins and purpose." [Wikisource](#) It found "no empirical evidence" of reverse-engineering and traced claims to "circular reporting." AARO did note one important caveat verbatim: "Although at least one interviewee claimed to have seen a captured UAP, none of the interviewees had direct access to or firsthand knowledge of the programs alleged to be UAP-related." Acting director Tim Phillips summarized: claims of hidden programs "are largely the result of circular reporting in which a small group of individuals have repeated inaccurate claims they have heard from others over a period of several decades."

Were the witnesses Grusch interviewed themselves firsthand? This is the crux. Grusch repeatedly characterized his sources as having "direct knowledge" and being "currently still on the program." AARO's finding directly contradicts this, asserting that the people in this network lacked firsthand program access. The dispute is therefore not really about

whether *Grusch* is firsthand (he largely concedes for 2023 that he is not) but whether his *sources* were — and AARO concluded they were not.

Scientific community: NASA UAP panelist Joshua Semeter: Grusch's claims are "two steps removed ... he also has not personally seen or touched any of the objects he references." Astrophysicist Adam Frank: it is "all just hearsay" — "a guy says he knows a guy who knows another guy that the government has alien spaceships." The Pentagon (spokesperson Sue Gough), NASA, and Gen. Mark Milley have all stated they found no verifiable evidence supporting the underlying claims.

Recommendations (for a reader assessing the claims)

1. **Treat 2023 claims as secondhand-with-firsthand-document-review.** The precise position: Grusch personally interviewed witnesses and personally reviewed some documents/photographs, but did not personally observe craft or bodies and relied on others' analyses for the "non-human" determination. Avoid both the oversimplified "purely secondhand" framing (it ignores his firsthand document/photo review and witness interviews) and any framing that implies he

personally saw craft or bodies in 2023 (he explicitly denied this under oath).

2. **Treat the November 2025 Fox/Baier statements as a distinct, escalated firsthand claim** — but note it is firsthand to *intelligence reports and imagery*, not to physical craft/bodies, and it remains unverified and uncorroborated by any released evidence. The decisive benchmark is whether the underlying reports/photos are ever produced.
3. **Separate the "credible and urgent" ICIG finding from the truth of the UFO claims.** That finding concerns his reprisal/withholding complaint, not the existence of alien craft. Do not cite it as validation of the substantive claims.
4. **Weight the AARO finding heavily on the sourcing question.** The single most decisive evidence-based rebuttal is AARO's conclusion that the source network lacked firsthand program access — which, if correct, collapses the secondhand chain regardless of Grusch's sincerity.
5. **Benchmarks that would change the assessment:** production of the classified reports/photographs Grusch says he read; on-the-record testimony from a named source with verified firsthand program access; or independent confirmation of the "slush funds" via appropriations records. Absent these, the claims remain testimony-based, not evidence-based.

Caveats

- Several 2026 statements (the "sentient plasma life" basis, the alleged February 2026 "first-hand exposure to non-human sentient beings," and characterizations of the June 9, 2026 remarks as describing personal "exposure" to a reverse-engineering program) rest substantially on UFO-enthusiast aggregator sites rather than primary transcripts; they should be treated as unconfirmed pending primary footage. The verbatim June 9, 2026 quotes ("slush funds," "sentient plasma life") are corroborated by mainstream outlets (Fox News, Washington Examiner, Reuters wire coverage).
- The full Coulthart NewsNation interview (reportedly ~7 hours) and Grusch's classified congressional testimony are not public, so some framing must be inferred from the cleared/public portions.
- Grusch's framing has demonstrably shifted over time (2023 "speaking to the facts as I have been told them" → 2025 "saw it ... with [his] own eyes"). This evolution is itself a contested data point: critics argue it tracks his regained clearance and new political role (Special Advisor to Rep. Burlison) rather than the emergence of new

evidence, since no new physical proof has been made public.

- This analysis addresses only the *epistemic basis Grusch claims* for each assertion — i.e., where he sits on the firsthand–secondhand spectrum. It does not, and cannot, adjudicate whether the underlying claims are true; every official body that has examined them (AARO, DoD, NASA) has reported finding no verifiable supporting evidence.